

ANCIENT HISTORY



MODULE - 13

MAURYAN DYNASTY

PART-1

OUR APPROACH TO FIND HISTORY FROM MYSTERY?

PRE - HISTORY

The period of time before written records.

- Stone Age
- Metal Age

PROTO - HISTORY

IVC

Aryan Invasion

VEDIC AGE
(1500 – 500 B.C.)

EARLY VEDIC AGE
(1500 – 1000 B.C.)

LATER VEDIC AGE
(1000 – 500 B.C.)

RELIGION & PHILOSOPHY



JAINISM



BUDDHISM

HISTORIC PERIOD

MAHAJANAPADAS

TERRITORIAL EXPANSION

MAGADHA

NANDA DYNASTY

Alexander Invasion

MAURYAN DYNASTY

MAURYAN DYNASTY

GUPTA DYNASTY

Foreign Invasion

KUSHAN EMPIRE

SATAVAHANAS

PUSHYABHUTHI DYNASTY

Huns Invasion

CHALUKYAS

PALLAVAS

SANGAM AGE

CHOLA

CHERA

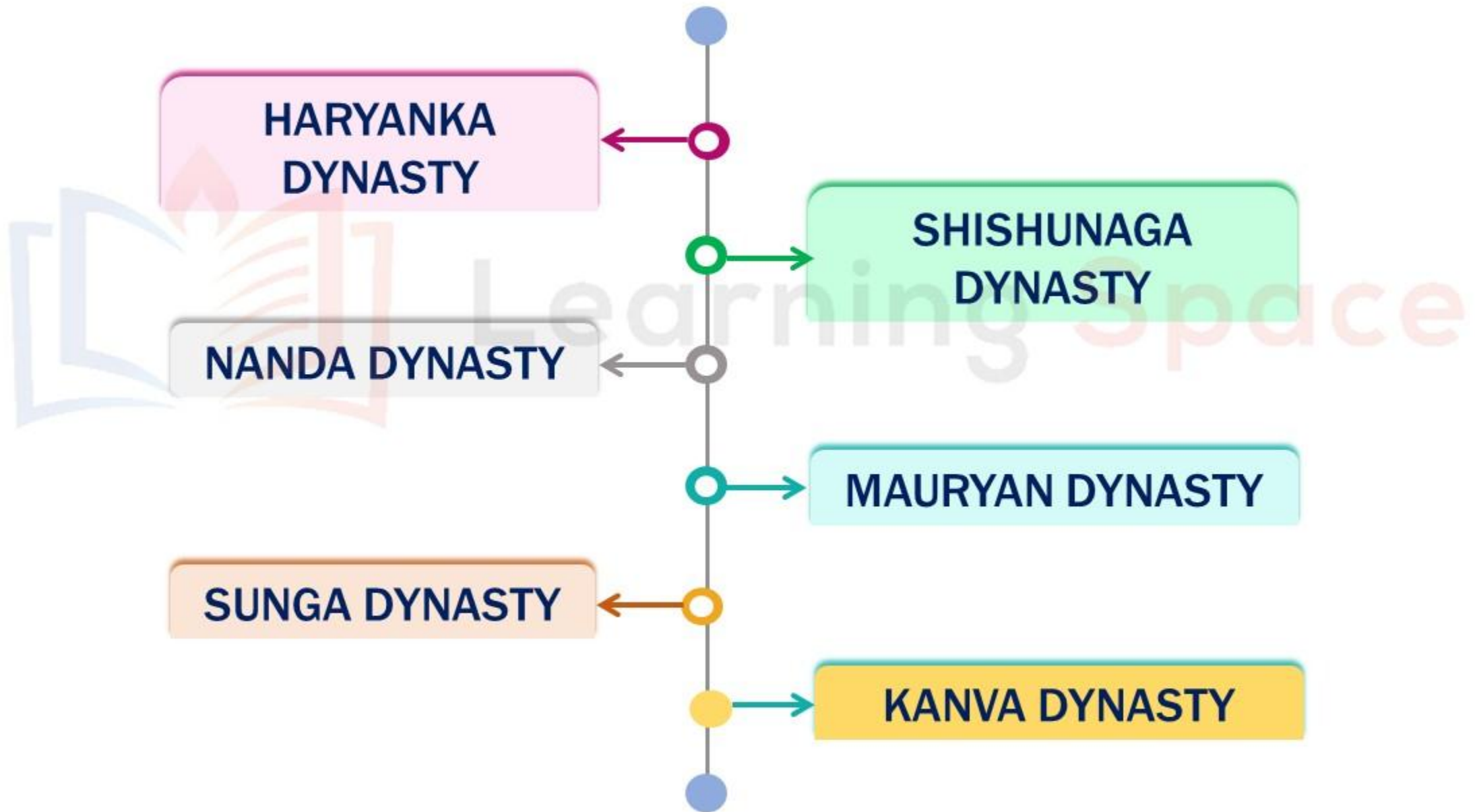
PANDYA

MAUKHARIS

VAKATAKAS

KADAMBAS

MAGADHAN DYNASTIES





MAURYAN DYNASTY

321 BC – 185 BC

ABOUT THE DYNASTY

SOURCES

KINGS AND THEIR CONTRIBUTION

CONSOLIDATION OF EMPIRE AND TERRITORIAL EXTENT

POLITICAL STRUCTURE/ SOCIAL LIFE/ ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT

SIGNIFICANCE OF THE DYNASTY

HOW DYNASTY DECLINED

OTHER FACTS

ABOUT THE DYNASTY

Chanakya who was scholar in Taxila university, wanted to apply for this post and he went to Dhanananda court.

The last ruler of Nanda dynasty, Dhanananda wanted a **Brahmin to run the Daankendra** i.e. charity centre.

Dhanananda by looking at his dirty look called him '**ugly Brahmin**' and insulted him.

Chanakya felt humiliated and **vowed** that he **would not re-tie his Brahmin knot** until he had driven king Nanda out of power and **destroy his clan**.



To take revenge, he groomed **Chandragupta Maurya**, who is thought to be the son of Dhanananda and **concubine Mura, a Shudra** women.

Added to this there was also a large scale **public resentment in the society** due to aggressive and oppressive nature of Dhanananda so people too wanted to get rid of this rule.

A SLICE INTO HISTORY

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THE SOURCES OF MAURYAN DYNASTY

ARCHAEOLOGICAL

LITERARY

RELIGIOUS

- Buddhist scripture - Dipavamsa and Mahavamsa
- Jain scriptures

SECULAR

TRAVELLER'S MEMORIES

Megasthene's Indica

TREATISES

Sangam Tamil literature

PLAYS / DRAMAS / POEMS

- Kautilya's Arthashastra
- Kalhana rajtarangni
- Visakadatta's Mudrarakshasa
- Kalidasa's Malvikagnimitram

COINS

(Numismatics)



MONUMENTS

STUPAS, VIHARAS



ARTIFACTS & OBJECTS



INSCRIPTIONS AND EDICTS



OTHERS



MAURYAN DYNASTY

(321 BC TO 185 BC)

ARCHAEOLOGICAL SOURCES

They are written in

- 5 languages
- 3 scripts.

INSCRIPTION

PALI

PRAKRIT

SANSKRIT

GREEK

ARAMIC

MAGDHI /
ARDHMAGDHI

BRAHMI

KHAROSHTHI

Junagarh pillar inscription

- Junagarh Rock Inscription or **Girnar inscription** of Rudradaman-I (saka ruler) mentions that **Sudarshan lake was constructed by the Mauryas.**
- It was a dam built by Mauryas to check floods.

Rummindei Pillar Inscription

- This discusses about Asoka's visit to Lumbini & exemption of Lumbini from tax.
- This is the **first direct archaeological evidence of Buddha's birth in Lumbini.**

MAURYAN DYNASTY

(321 BC TO 185 BC)

ARCHAEOLOGICAL SOURCES

The **XIII Rock Edict** gives details about his war with **Kalinga**.

The **Pillar Edict VII** gives a summary of his efforts to promote the **Dhamma** within his kingdom

Edicts of Asoka deal with **Asoka's Dhamma** and also instructions given to his officials.

An edict is an **official order or proclamation** issued by a person in authority.

In most of the edicts, Ashoka is mentioned as **Devanampiya and Piyadassi**.

Maski edict mentions his name as Asoka. This site is near Tungabhadra river in Karnataka's Raichur District.



EDICTS

THE SOURCES OF MAURYAN DYNASTY

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STUPAS, VIHARAS



ARTIFACTS & OBJECTS



INSCRIPTIONS AND EDICTS



OTHERS



MAURYAN DYNASTY

(321 BC TO 185 BC)

LITERARY SOURCES

4 Visakadatta's Mudrarakshasa

- It is a drama in Sanskrit.
- Written during the Gupta period.
- It describes how **Chandragupta with the assistance of Kautilya overthrew the Nandas.**
- It also gives a picture on the socio-economic condition under the Mauryas.

3 Kalhana rajtarangni

- Written in Sanskrit language.
- It mentioned that city of **srinagar was under Ashoka.**

1 Kautilya's Arthasastra

- Written in Sanskrit.
- This book can be divided into 3 parts
 - ✓ The first deals with the king and his council
 - ✓ The second with civil and criminal law and
 - ✓ The third with diplomacy and war.

2 Sangam Tamil literature

Confirms the Mauryan invasion of far south.

LITERARY
SOURCES

MAURYAN DYNASTY

(321 BC TO 185 BC)

LITERARY SOURCES

8

Malvikagnimitram

Written by Kalidasa throws enough light on the last years of the Mauryan rule

5

Dipavamsa and Mahavamsa-

- Chronicles are written in pali.
- It is a Buddhist text of Srilanka, mention about son and daughter of Asoka that they came to srilanka and planted a Bodhi tree.

6

Megasthenes' Indica

- Greek ambassador in the court of Chandragupta Maurya.
- He gives details about Mauryan administration and social life.

7

Jain scriptures

These refer to Chandragupta's death

LITERARY
SOURCES

MAURYAN ERA

LITERARY GENIUS

VISHAKHADUTTA

- Vishakhadatta was one of the famous Sanskrit poet and play writer during Gupta period
- Two important plays are: the Mudrārākṣasa and the Devichandraguptam

KALIDASA

- Greatest poet and dramatist in the Sanskrit language of India.
- He was one of the nine jewels during gupta empire.

LITERARY GENIUS

KAUTILYA

- Kautilya also known as Chanakya or Vishnu gupta, the Prime Minister of Chandragupta Maurya.
- He was also called 'Indian Machiavelli'.
- His book describes how a good government should be organized.

MEGASTHENES

- He was the ambassador of Seleucus Nicator at the court of Chandragupta.
- He wrote not only about the capital city of Pataliputra but also about the Maurya Empire as a whole and about the society.

KALHANA

- Kalhana a Kashmiri, was the author of Rajatarangini (River of Kings), an account of the history of Kashmir

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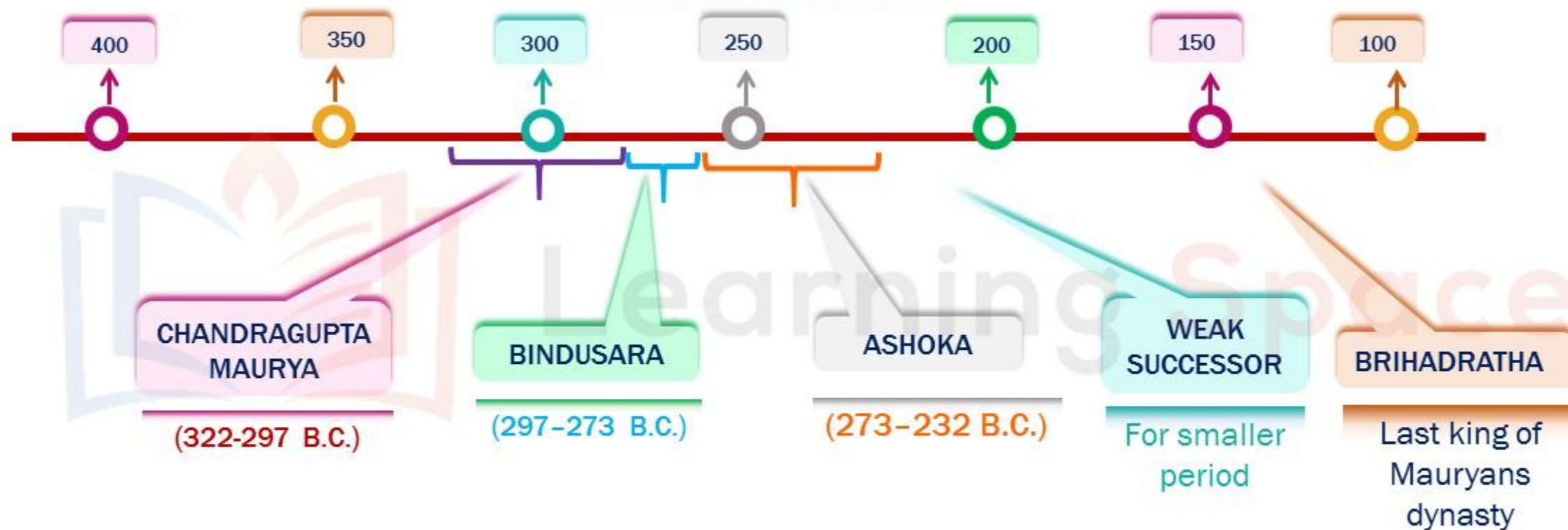
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MAURYAN ERA

GENEAOLOGY



Last king of **Mauryans** dynasty was **Brihadratha** who, was murdered by his general **Pushyamitra Sunga** and who ascended the throne in 185 B.C. Thus the empire founded by him after Mauryans is known as **Sunga Dynasty**.

KINGS AND THEIR CONTRIBUTION

In 305 B.C., he **marched against Selukas Niketar, Alexander's General**. He defeated him and signed a treaty.

He was the **founder**. He defeated Nanda dynasty with the assistance of Kautilya.

By this treaty, Selukas Niketar **ceded the trans-Indus territories** – to Mauryan Empire.

Megasthenes was sent to Mauryan court as Greek ambassador.

He **embraced Jainism** towards the end of his life and stepped down from the throne in favour of his son Bindusara.

Then he went to Sravana Belgola, near Mysore along with Jain monks led by Bhadrabahu and **practice sallekhana**. Bhadrabahu Cave is the place where he is said to have died by fasting.

CHANDRAGUPTA MAURYA

**CHANDRAGUPTA MAURYA
(322-298 BC)**

MAURYAN DYNASTY

(321 BC TO 185 BC)

BINDUSARA

(298 – 273 B.C.)

1 He was called as “**Amitragatha**” meaning slayer of enemies by Greeks.

2 He **supported the Ajivikas**, a religious sect.

CHANDRAGUPTA

BINDUSARA

ASHOKA

JAINISM

AJIVIKAS

BUDDHISM

RELATION WITH SYRIANS

1 Syrian king Antiochus I sent **Deimachus** as ambassador to the court of Bindusara.

2 Bindusara wrote to Antiochus I asking for sweet wine, dried figs and a sophist.

3 Antiochus I sent all but not a sophist because the Greek law prohibited sending a sophist.

MAURYAN DYNASTY

(321 BC TO 185 BC)

ASOKA THE GREAT

(273 – 232 B.C.)

1

When Bindusara was ruling, Ashoka was serving as Governor of Taxila and Ujjain.

2

After Bindusara's death there was **constant power struggle** for continuous 4 years.

3

According to Ceylonese Chronicles, **Dipavamsa** and **Mahavamsa** state, Ashoka captured power after killing his 99 brothers.



4

That's the reason there was an interval of four years between Asoka's accession to the throne (273 B.C.) and his actual coronation (269 B.C.).



5

Most important event during Ashoka reign was victorious war with **Kalinga** in **261 B.C.**



MAURYAN DYNASTY

(321 BC TO 185 BC)

ASOKA THE GREAT

(273 – 232 B.C.)



BATTLE OF KALINGA

DIGVIJAY



DHAMMAVIJAY

KALINGA WAR, 261 BC

- 1 He invaded and annexed Kalinga (on River Daya) mainly because *Kalinga controlled land and sea routes to South India.*
- 2 The *death, destruction, violence and bloodshed* of the war left a permanent impression on mind of Ashoka. War *changed his attitude from Digvijay to Dhammavijay.*
- 3 Kalinga was his first conquest which became the last, instead of encouraging him for further conquests.

MAURYAN DYNASTY

(321 BC TO 185 BC)

ASOKA THE GREAT

(273 – 232 B.C.)

PATH TOWARDS BUDDHISM

His conversion to Buddhism was gradual and not immediate.

He became Sakya Upasaka (lay disciple) and two and a half years later, a Bikshu (monk).

Then he gave up hunting, visited Bodh-Gaya, and organized missions.



ASOKA AND BUDDHISM

Under the influence of Buddhist monk, Upagupta (Nigrodh) in 9th year of his reign after winning Kalinga he embraced Buddhism.

Later, he met Moggaliputta Tissa, who ultimately become his mentor.

He visited birth place of Buddha, Lumbini Garden, near Kapilavastu; Sarnath, Sravasti and Kusinagara.

Buddhism remained his personal belief.

MAURYAN DYNASTY

(321 BC TO 185 BC)

ASOKA THE GREAT

(273 – 232 B.C.)

ASOKA AND BUDDHISM



- 1 He sent a mission to Sri Lanka under his son Mahendra and daughter Sangamitra who planted there the branch of the original Bodhi tree.

EFFORTS TO SPREAD BUDDHISM

- 2 He appointed special officers called Dharma Mahamatras to speed up progress of Dhamma.
- 3 He convened 3rd Buddhist Council at Pataliputra in 240 B.C. in order to strengthen the Sangha. It was presided over by Moggaliputta Tissa. Abhidhamma Pitaka was established in this council.

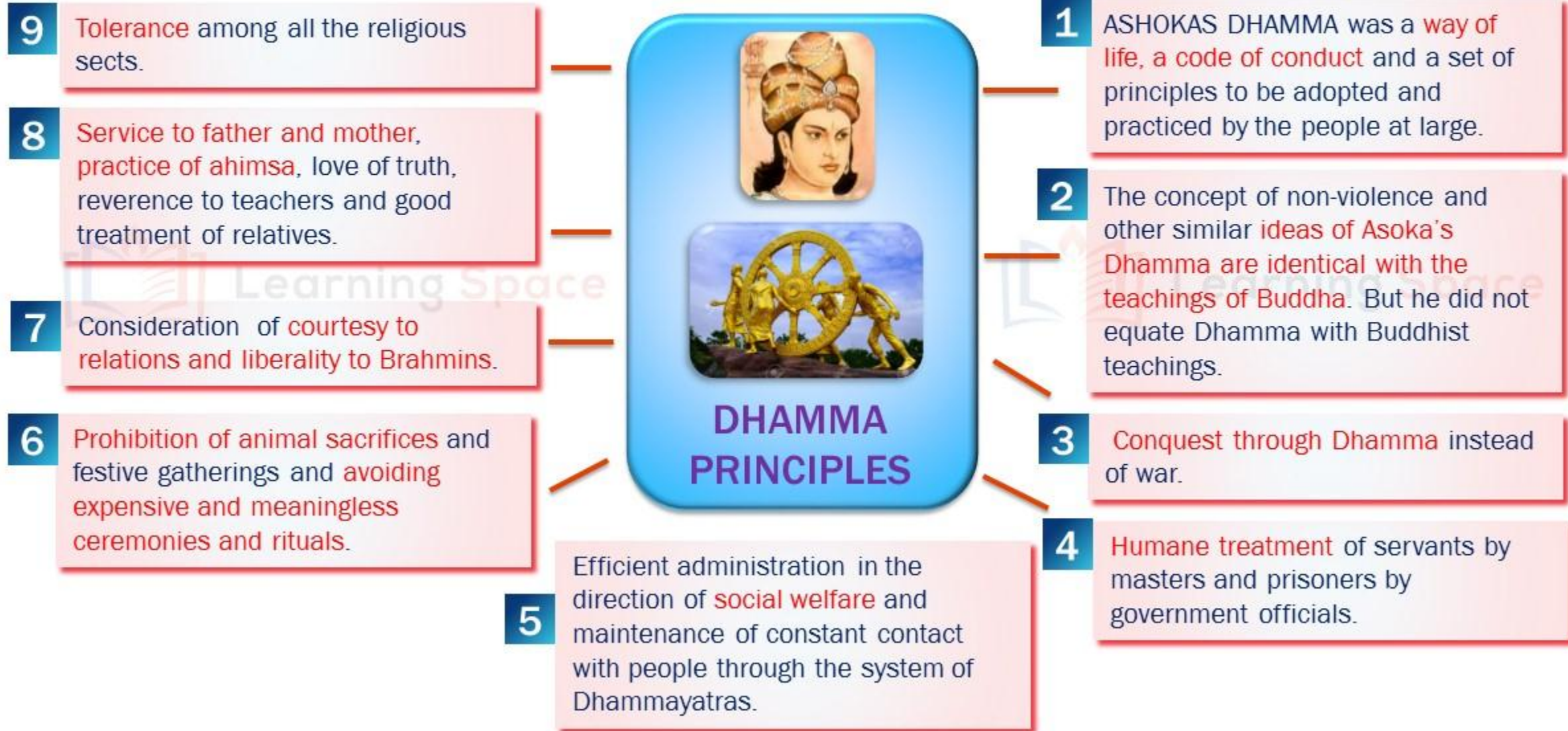
BUDDHIST COUNCIL

COUNCIL	WHEN AND WHERE	PATRONAGED AND PRESIDED BY	MOTIVE
FIRST BUDDHIST COUNCIL	400BCE, RAJGRIHA	KING AJATASHATRU- HARNAKYA DYNASTY MAHAKASYAPA	- To preserve buddha's teachings. - Vinayapitaka(recited by upali) and suttapitaka (recited by ananda) were written
SECOND BUDDHIST COUNCIL	383BCE, VAISHALI	KING KALASHOKA-SISUNAGA DYNASTY SABAKAMI	To settle the dispute on Vinaya pitaka , the code of discipline
THIRD BUDDHIST COUNCIL	250BCE, PATALIPUTRA	KING ASHOKA- MAURYAN DYNASTY MOGGALIPUTTA TISSA	- Abhidamma pitaka was established . - All the 3 pitakas were known as 'tripataka'
FOURTH BUDDHIST COUNCIL	72AD, KUNDALVANA, KASHMIR	KING KANISHKA VASUMITRA WITH ASVAGHOSHA AS HIS DEPUTY	Buddhism was divided into 2 sects- Mahayana and hinayana.

ASOKA THE GREAT

(273 – 232 B.C.)

MAIN FEATURES OF ASOKA'S DHAMMA



MAURYAN ERA

ASOKA THE GREAT (273 – 232 B.C.)

EXTENT OF ASOKA'S EMPIRE



- 1 Asoka's inscriptions mention the southernmost kingdoms – Cholas, Pandyas, Satyaputras and Keralaputras – as border-states.
- 2 According to Rajatarangini, Kashmir was a part of the Mauryan Empire.
- 3 Nepal was also within the Mauryan empire.

MAURYAN ERA

ASOKA THE GREAT

(273 – 232 B.C.)

ESTIMATE OF ASOKA AS A KING



1 Asoka was “the greatest of kings”.

2 He was an example in history for his benevolent administration and also for following the policy of non-aggression even after his victory in the war.

3 He was not a dreamer but a man of practical genius.

4 His central ideal was to promote the welfare of humanity.

5 His Dhamma is so universal that it appeals to humanity even today.

6 Asoka was true to his ideals.

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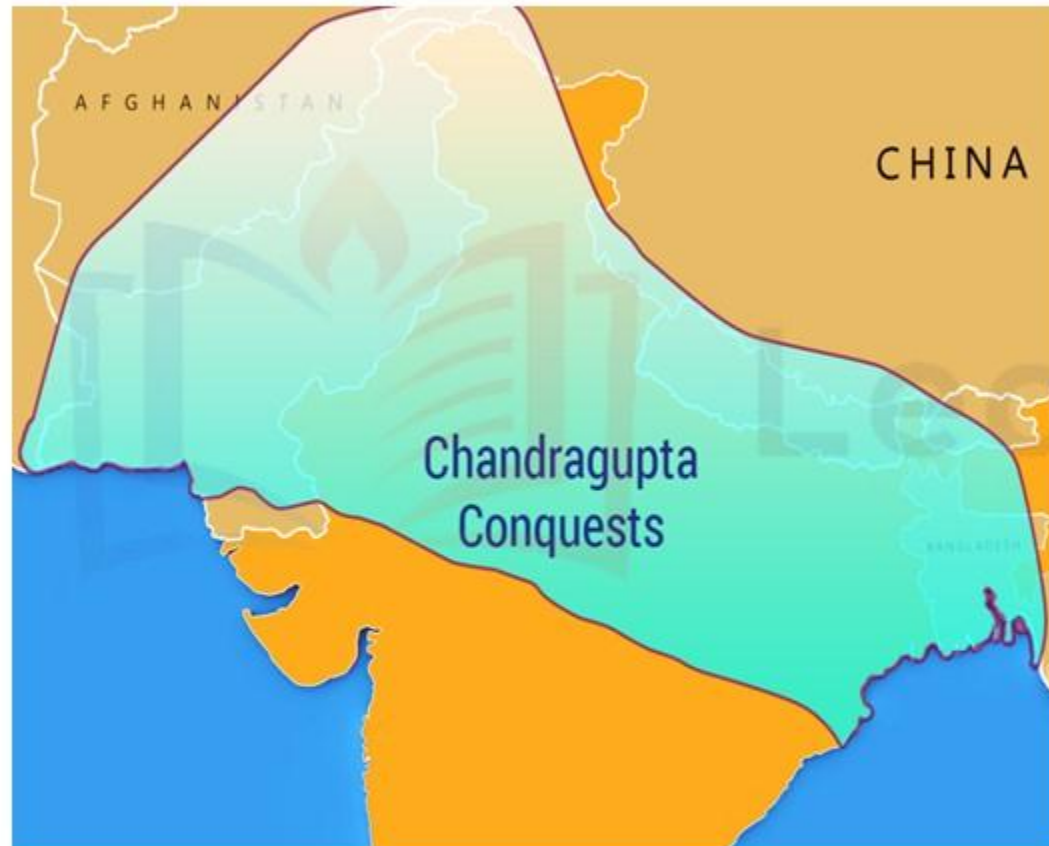


1 Magadha region

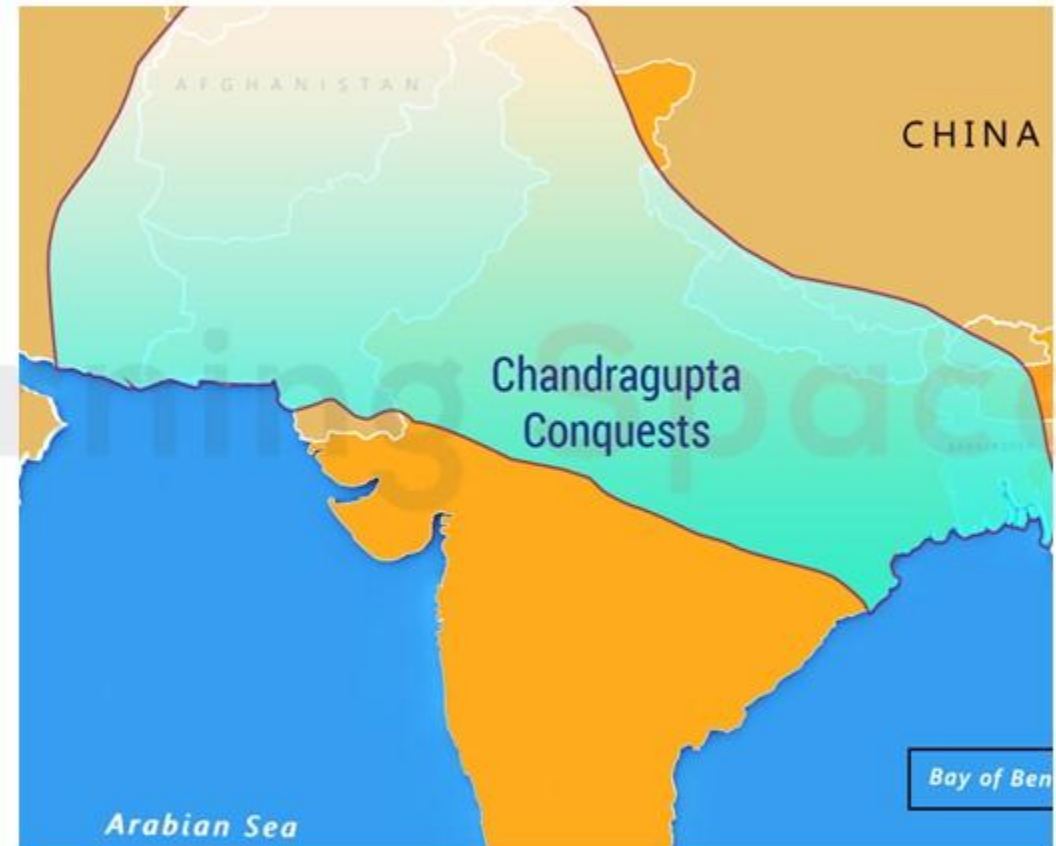


2 Under Nanda rule

CONSOLIDATION OF EMPIRE AND TERRITORIAL EXTENT



- 3** When Chandragupta Maurya defeated Nanda dynasty



- 4** Due to Alexander invasion, there was political vacuum in north-west region which proved advantageous to Mauryans.

CONSOLIDATION OF EMPIRE AND TERRITORIAL EXTENT



- 5** Bindusara rule.
He expanded the empire till
deccan region



- 6** Ashoka rule
By conquering Kalinga, first time
the whole of Indian subcontinent
was united politically

MAURYAN DYNASTY

(321 BC TO 185 BC)

LATER MAURYANS

LATER MAURYANS

WESTERN PART

- Ruled by Kunala, son of Asoka
- Due to the **Bactrian invasions**, the **western part of the empire collapsed.**

EASTERN PART

- Ruled by Dasaratha, one of grandsons of Ashoka
- It continued under Mauryan empire, until Shunga took over.

1

Asoka's death in 232 B.C. was followed by the division of the Mauryan Empire into two parts – western and eastern.

2

By this time, there were repeated attacks of **Yavanas / Greeks** from **western** side.

3

The last Mauryan king was Brihadratha, who was assassinated by Pushyamitra Sunga (his commander) and led to the establishment of Sunga Dynasty.

Q & A

Q. 1 Who of the following had first deciphered the edicts of Emperor Ashoka?

- a) Georg Buhler
- b) James Prinsep
- c) Max Muller
- d) William Jones

ANSWER

b) James Prinsep

Q & A

Q. 2 The ancient Indian play Mudrarakshasa of Visakhadutta has its subject as

- a) A conflict between Gods and demons of ancient Hindu lore
- b) A romantic story of an Aryan prince and a tribal woman
- c) The story of the power struggle between two Aryan tribes
- d) The court intrigues at the time of Chandragupta Maurya

ANSWER

d) The court intrigues at the time of Chandragupta Maurya.

Q & A

Q. 3 Which one of the following edicts mentions the personal name of Ashoka?

- a) Kalsi
- b) Rummindei
- c) Special Kalinga edict
- d) Maski

ANSWER

d) Maski

Q & A

Q.4 The name by which Ashoka is generally referred to in his inscriptions is

- a) Chakravarti
- b) Dharmadeva
- c) Dharmakirti
- d) Piyadassi

ANSWER

d) Piyadassi

THOUGHT PROVOKING QUESTIONS

- Q.1** Discuss about the nature of Ashoka's Dhamma and critically evaluate it in terms of constitutional principles.
- Q.2** Discuss about the nature of Ashoka's Dhamma and how it is different from Buddhism.

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